Chapter One

It was a bright cold day in April, and the clocks were striking thirteen.
The old house at the end of the street had been empty for many years.
Nobody remembered who had lived there, but everyone had a story about it.
Some said a sailor had built it with wood from his shipwrecked boat,
and others whispered that the garden was full of forgotten treasures.
Emma did not believe any of these stories, yet every morning on her way
to school she slowed down in front of the rusty gate and looked inside.

Chapter Two

One rainy afternoon, Emma noticed that the gate had been left ajar. A narrow path, half hidden by brambles, led towards the front door. She hesitated for a long moment, listening to the rain on the leaves, then pushed the gate and stepped carefully into the overgrown garden.

Chapter Three

The front door was locked, but a small window beside it was broken. Through the gap, Emma could see a dusty hall and a staircase of dark oak. On the bottom step lay a leather notebook, its pages swollen with damp. She knew, at that very instant, that her life was about to change.